

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Finance English

Conversation lab

12 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 Monthly Close: Revenue Miss or Timing Issue?
- 02 Forecast Review: Aggressive Sales Assumptions
- 03 Cash Runway: Profit Is Not Cash
- 04 Covenant Monitoring: Early Warning
- 05 Investment Committee: Duration and Spread Risk
- 06 Credit Underwriting: Strong Growth, Weak Coverage
- 07 M&A Diligence: EBITDA Add-Back Challenge
- 08 Pricing and Margin: Discounting Pressure
- 09 Audit Issue: Control Deficiency or Material Weakness?
- 10 FX Hedge Debate
- 11 Performance Presentation: Fair, Accurate, Complete
- 12 Board Update: Liquidity, Leverage, and Capital Allocation

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Monthly Close: Revenue Miss or Timing Issue?

Finance reviews monthly results before sending the executive package.

Roles: Controller / FP&A lead / Finance business partner

Controller: Revenue is 4 percent below forecast. Is this a real miss or timing?

FP&A lead: Part of it is timing. Two enterprise renewals slipped into next month.

Finance business partner: Can we separate accounting timing from underlying demand? Revenue recognition depends on the actual contracts, performance, and applicable accounting policy, not just signature date. Let's reconcile those details before calling this a timing-only variance.

Controller: What should the commentary say?

Finance business partner: The renewals are one reported driver, but the accounting bridge still needs verification. We should also assess the SMB churn data before drawing a conclusion about recurring demand.

Controller: I will reconcile renewal timing with the revenue-recognition entries before we finalize the bridge.

Finance business partner: Please include the churn evidence and distinguish confirmed drivers from the open analysis.

Notice the professional language

Good finance commentary separates accounting timing from business demand.

A variance explanation should state driver, recurrence, confidence, and risk.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Forecast Review: Aggressive Sales Assumptions

A business unit submits a forecast that assumes a sharp Q4 recovery.

Roles: Business owner / CFO / Finance business partner

Business owner: The pipeline supports the forecast. We just need the team to execute.

CFO: Pipeline is not the same as committed revenue.

Finance business partner: The upside case is possible, but the base case should reflect conversion rate, sales-cycle length, and historical slippage. What evidence supports a conversion rate above the trailing average?

Business owner: We have a new campaign.

Finance business partner: Then I would model the campaign as a sensitivity, not the base case, until we see qualified leads converting.

Business owner: I will supply historical conversion and slippage by stage.

Finance business partner: Then we can compare a defensible base case with the proposed upside.

Notice the professional language

Respectful pushback focuses on assumptions and evidence.

Finance language can separate base case, upside case, and sensitivity.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Cash Runway: Profit Is Not Cash

A startup leadership team reviews runway after slower collections.

Roles: CEO / Treasury / Finance business partner

CEO: We are close to breakeven, so why is cash still tight?

Treasury: Collections slowed, and prepaid annual contracts are lower than planned.

Finance business partner: The income statement improved, but working capital moved against us. DSO increased, and deferred revenue growth slowed, so cash came in later than revenue recognition suggests.

CEO: What levers do we have?

Finance business partner: We can assess collections, spending timing, and funding scenarios with the responsible teams. The cash forecast should show assumptions and constraints explicitly, including any financing that is not yet available.

CEO: I will update the receipts schedule and identify what remains unconfirmed.

Finance business partner: Bring that alongside the downside cash outlook so management can assess actual flexibility.

Notice the professional language

Deferred revenue - Cash received before revenue is recognized.

Working capital - Operational assets and liabilities such as receivables, inventory, and payables.

DSO - Days sales outstanding; a measure of collection speed for receivables.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Covenant Monitoring: Early Warning

Treasury sees leverage approaching a covenant threshold.

Roles: Treasurer / Business unit CFO / Finance business partner

Treasurer: If Q3 EBITDA lands at the downside case, leverage gets close to the covenant.

Business unit CFO: But we will not breach unless Q4 is also weak.

Finance business partner: True, but we should treat this as an early warning. The lender conversation is easier before a breach than after one.

Treasurer: What do we need?

Finance business partner: A rolling covenant forecast, downside mitigation plan, and a decision on whether to seek an amendment, add equity cushion, or reduce discretionary spend.

Treasurer: I will check the definitions and thresholds in the actual loan agreement.

Finance business partner: Use those in the forecast and route any proposed lender discussion through the authorized team.

Notice the professional language

EBITDA - Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization; often adjusted but not a cash-flow substitute.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Investment Committee: Duration and Spread Risk

A portfolio manager explains fixed-income underperformance.

Roles: Client / Portfolio manager / Finance business partner

Client: Why did we underperform if the bond portfolio is conservative?

Portfolio manager: Rates moved higher, and credit spreads widened at the same time.

Finance business partner: The portfolio stayed within mandate, but duration exposure hurt absolute returns, and spread widening hurt relative performance versus short-duration peers.

Client: Should we reduce risk now?

Finance business partner: We can shorten duration, improve credit quality, or hold the allocation if your horizon supports it. The tradeoff is lower rate sensitivity versus potential income and reinvestment opportunity.

Client: I will compare the options against the mandate and current objectives.

Finance business partner: Please include the risks and assumptions before requesting an investment decision.

Notice the professional language

Client communication should explain performance without making hindsight sound easy.

Use mandate, benchmark, horizon, and tradeoff language.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Credit Underwriting: Strong Growth, Weak Coverage

A bank credit committee reviews a borrower seeking a larger facility.

Roles: Relationship manager / Credit officer / Finance business partner

Relationship manager: The borrower is growing fast and wants more capacity.

Credit officer: Growth is good, but cash conversion is weak.

Finance business partner: Revenue growth does not automatically support more debt. DSCR is below our target in the downside case, and customer concentration increases repayment risk.

Relationship manager: What structure would make it approvable?

Finance business partner: We can evaluate structures and conditions through credit review, but none of those changes guarantees approval. Let's compare the downside cash flows and risk implications before recommending terms.

Relationship manager: I will collect the updated borrower records and confirm their reporting period.

Finance business partner: Then credit can assess the request using the complete file.

Notice the professional language

DSCR - Debt service coverage ratio; cash flow relative to required debt payments.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

M&A Diligence: EBITDA Add-Back Challenge

Corporate development reviews seller-adjusted EBITDA.

Roles: Seller advisor / Buyer finance / Finance business partner / Deal lead

Seller advisor: The adjusted EBITDA add-backs are standard. These costs are non-recurring.

Buyer finance: Some of them appear to be ongoing operating costs.

Finance business partner: We can accept one-time legal settlement costs if documented, but the customer support add-back looks recurring. Removing it lowers EBITDA and increases the purchase multiple.

Deal lead: How should we proceed?

Finance business partner: Request support for each add-back and assess its effect on normalized earnings and valuation. Working-capital mechanisms and contingent consideration address different deal questions and need their own analysis and qualified review.

Seller advisor: I will request documentary support for each disputed adjustment.

Finance business partner: Keep the seller's assertion separate from the buyer's verified analysis.

Notice the professional language

EBITDA - Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization; often adjusted but not a cash-flow substitute.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Pricing and Margin: Discounting Pressure

Sales wants approval for a large discount to close a strategic customer.

Roles: Sales / Finance / Finance business partner

Sales: If we approve the discount, we close the logo this quarter.

Finance: The discount compresses gross margin and sets a pricing precedent.

Finance business partner: Can we separate strategic value from unit economics? The deal may be worth doing, but the base price should not become the reference point for renewals or similar customers.

Sales: What is the finance recommendation?

Finance business partner: I would compare the proposed terms and longer-term margin effects before recommending approval. Any discount, volume commitment, or renewal provision still needs the required commercial authorization.

Sales: I will send the full proposed commercial terms for review.

Finance business partner: Include the renewal assumptions so the evaluation covers more than the initial booking.

Notice the professional language

Gross margin - Revenue minus cost of goods or services, often expressed as a percentage of revenue.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 09 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Audit Issue: Control Deficiency or Material Weakness?

An audit team finds repeated manual journal-entry approvals after posting.

Roles: Auditor / Controller / Finance business partner

Auditor: Approvals occurred after posting in several samples.

Controller: The entries were correct, so I do not see the issue.

Finance business partner: Accuracy helps, but the control objective is timely review before posting. A correct entry can still reveal an operating deficiency.

Controller: Are you saying it is a material weakness?

Finance business partner: Not from this evidence alone. We need to assess frequency, magnitude, compensating controls, and whether a material misstatement could reasonably occur.

Auditor: I will gather the sampling details and the control-design evidence.

Finance business partner: That will support a properly scoped assessment instead of a premature severity label.

Notice the professional language

Material weakness - A serious control deficiency creating reasonable possibility of material misstatement.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 10 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

FX Hedge Debate

A multinational company faces euro-denominated costs and dollar revenue.

Roles: Operations / Treasury / Finance business partner

Operations: The euro moved against us. Can treasury just lock the rate?

Treasury: We can hedge part of the exposure, but hedging has cost and forecast risk.

Finance business partner: The exposure is not only today's spot rate. We need forecasted euro costs, timing, confidence, hedge ratio, and whether the hedge qualifies for the accounting treatment we expect.

Operations: So what do you recommend?

Finance business partner: We should assess eligible hedging options against the treasury policy, exposure evidence, costs, and accounting requirements with qualified reviewers before recommending or executing a transaction.

Operations: I will reconcile the forecast exposure with the purchase schedule.

Finance business partner: Show the uncertainty in amount and timing before treasury reviews the alternatives.

Notice the professional language

Hedging reduces certain risks but can create cost, accounting, and forecast challenges.

Use exposure, hedge ratio, timing, and accounting-treatment language.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 11 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Performance Presentation: Fair, Accurate, Complete

A wealth team prepares a client deck after a strong quarter.

Roles: Advisor / Compliance / Finance business partner

Advisor: Let's lead with our best-performing strategy.

Compliance: Only if the performance presentation is balanced and not misleading.

Finance business partner: We should include benchmark, time period, fees basis, relevant risks, and whether the result is representative. A single strong quarter without context may create a misleading impression.

Advisor: Can we still use it?

Finance business partner: Potentially, after compliance review of the actual material and applicable requirements. Those presentation elements help provide context but do not automatically make a communication compliant.

Advisor: I will submit the complete slide and supporting figures to compliance.

Finance business partner: Keep its publication status pending until the required review is complete.

Notice the professional language

Investment performance language carries compliance and ethics risk.

Strong performance still needs context, risk, fees, and representativeness.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 12 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Board Update: Liquidity, Leverage, and Capital Allocation

The CFO briefs the board before approving a buyback and acquisition pipeline.

Roles: Board member / CFO / Finance business partner

Board member: Can we fund the buyback and still pursue the acquisition?

CFO: It depends on the downside case and debt capacity.

Finance business partner: Base case supports both, but the downside case tightens liquidity and pushes leverage close to our target ceiling. The decision is not only affordability; it is flexibility if revenue slows or rates stay higher.

Board member: What is management's recommendation?

Finance business partner: Authorize a smaller buyback tranche now, preserve capacity for diligence, and revisit after Q2 cash conversion and covenant forecast are updated.

Board member: I will bring the smaller tranche and alternative scenarios to the decision meeting.

Finance business partner: Include the required authorizations and preserve room to reassess as the evidence changes.

Notice the professional language

Board finance updates need recommendation, tradeoff, downside case, and decision trigger.

Capital allocation language connects cash, strategy, risk, and optionality.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

SHARED CASE

Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

SHARED CASE

An invoice covers services delivered in December but was paid in January. A colleague asks which month should appear in the close schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Are we discussing the cash payment date or the accounting period for the expense? The payment was in January; the accounting treatment needs to follow our policy and the service details.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

SHARED CASE

The forecast shows \$120,000 of spending against a \$100,000 budget. A new supplier fee accounts for \$15,000; the remaining \$5,000 is under review.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

Spending is forecast to be \$20,000 above budget. The supplier fee explains \$15,000 of that variance. We are still reviewing the remaining \$5,000 and will update the bridge tomorrow.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

SHARED CASE

A cash forecast assumes a large customer pays on Friday. The customer has not confirmed payment. A manager asks if the cash balance is guaranteed.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The forecast assumes payment on Friday; that date is not confirmed. I'll show the balance both with and without the receipt so the team can see the liquidity exposure.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

SHARED CASE

A portfolio return is 6% before fees. Its benchmark returned 5% over the same stated period. A slide does not identify fee treatment.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The figures suggest a one-percentage-point difference before fees. We should label fee treatment and confirm the comparison basis before describing the performance to a client.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

SHARED CASE

A credit file is missing an updated financial statement. The review team needs it for a scheduled meeting on Thursday.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you send the latest approved financial statements through the secure channel by Wednesday? Please confirm the reporting period, or let us know when the documents will be available.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

SHARED CASE

A reconciliation has three unmatched entries. Their cause is unknown. The preparer is handing the work to a reviewer at the end of the day.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

Three entries remain unmatched. I've listed their references and the checks already completed. Please review the supporting records and record the resolution; the cause is still unconfirmed.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

SHARED CASE

A valuation model changes materially when the growth assumption moves from 2% to 4%. The presentation shows only the higher estimate.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The valuation is sensitive to the growth assumption. I'll present both scenarios and explain the assumptions behind them. The higher figure is a modeled outcome, not an assured transaction value.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Dialogue 01: Monthly Close: Revenue Miss or Timing Issue?

Original fictional setting: Finance reviews monthly results before sending the executive package.

Professional roles: Controller / FP&A lead / Finance business partner

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Controller: Revenue is 4 percent below forecast. Is this a real miss or timing?

FP&A lead: Part of it is timing. Two enterprise renewals slipped into next month.

Finance business partner: Can we separate accounting timing from underlying demand? Revenue recognition depends on the actual contracts, performance, and applicable accounting policy, not just signature date. Let's reconcile those details before calling this a timing-only variance.

Controller: What should the commentary say?

Finance business partner: The renewals are one reported driver, but the accounting bridge still needs verification. We should also assess the SMB churn data before drawing a conclusion about recurring demand.

Controller: I will reconcile renewal timing with the revenue-recognition entries before we finalize the bridge.

Finance business partner: Please include the churn evidence and distinguish confirmed drivers from the open analysis.

Vocabulary in this exchange: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Forecast: Updated estimate of future performance based on current

information. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Bridge: Step-by-step explanation from one financial number to another. / Reconcile: Compare records, identify differences, and resolve them.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

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Create more scenario dialogues

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TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

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